

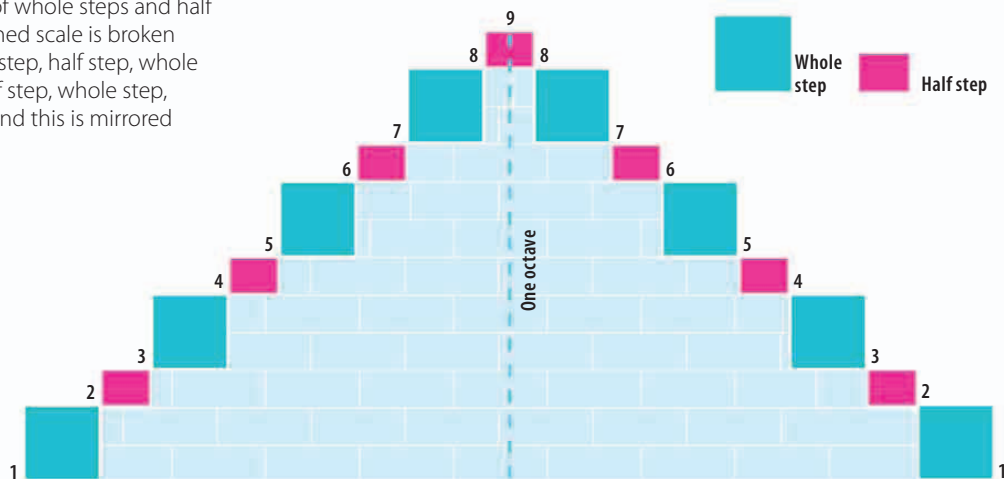


Diminished scales I

Diminished scales (also called octatonic scales) include a total of nine notes from top to bottom, and follow an alternating pattern of whole steps and half steps. The first type of diminished scale is broken down into the pattern: whole step, half step, whole step, half step, whole step, half step, whole step, half step, going up the scale, and this is mirrored going down the scale as well.

▷ Beginning with a whole step

This diminished scale begins with a whole step between its first two notes, and then alternates whole steps with half steps going up and down the scale.



Whole step between C and D, the first two notes of the scale.

Whole step between B and A, following the first half step going down the scale.

Half step between B and C at the top of the scale—the pattern of whole steps and half steps going up the scale is mirrored going down the scale.

Diminished scale starting on C

56 △ On the staff
Shown on the staff is a diminished scale starting on C. The interval between the first two notes is a whole step, the next interval is a half step, and the scale is broken down into alternating whole steps and half steps.

REAL WORLD

Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov (1844–1908)

Russian composers, such as Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov, used the diminished scale to make their music sound exotic, and to create a sense of magic and mystery. The diminished scale features prominently in Rimsky-Korsakov's opera *Kashchey the Immortal*, which is based on a Russian fairy tale about an evil wizard.



In his autobiography, **Rimsky-Korsakov** claimed to have **invented** the **diminished scale**. However, it is likely that the **scale dates back** as far as the **7th century**, and was **first used** in **traditional Persian music**.